

Constructed Environments and Autobiographical Conformity

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Abstract

This paper describes a pilot investigation into the effect of coherent, fictional local history on confidence in autobiographical recall. Participants encountered a constructed archive before completing guided interviews. The present document reports preliminary observations only; no inferential claims should be drawn from the pilot sample.

1. Constructed municipal history

The Morrowfield materials were designed to appear internally consistent across photographs, civic records, maps, and short newspaper accounts. Consistency was prioritized over realism: the archive required enough ordinary detail to sustain repeated examination without inviting a single obvious interpretive path.

2. Session protocol

Participants completed an initial guided-recall session, followed by staggered reviews and prompt-based follow-ups. Log numbers were maintained separately from public project materials. For this reason, a record's filed date is more useful for reconstructing sequence than the date displayed on public descriptions.

3. Preliminary observations

Participants frequently referred to landmarks they had encountered only in the constructed archive. Confidence increased when multiple records repeated the same detail, even where the detail was absent from the participant's own history. The pattern is consistent with source-monitoring uncertainty, though the small pilot does not support broader conclusions.

4. Limits

The pilot used a narrow sample and a short interval between exposures. It also relied on an archival interface maintained outside the ordinary laboratory staffing structure. Future studies should distinguish between confidence gained through repetition and confidence gained through trusted institutional presentation.

References

Calder, M. (2002). Institutional cues in source monitoring. *Bellwether working papers*, 14, 1-19.

Reed, J. (2003). Index order and recall prompts. *Departmental methods notes*, 7, 22-31.

5. Acknowledgements

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This working paper was withdrawn from the conference record at the author's request. The departmental copy is retained for accession review.